

Conceptual model

- A conceptual model is:
 - “...a high-level description of how a system is organized and operates” (Johnson and Henderson, 2002, p26)
- Enables
 - “...designers to straighten out their thinking before they start laying out their widgets” (Johnson and Henderson, 2002, p28)

Components

- Metaphors and analogies
 - understand what a product is for and how to use it for an activity
- Concepts that people are exposed to through the product
 - task–domain objects, their attributes, and operations (e.g. saving, revisiting, organizing)
- Relationship and mappings between these concepts
 - One can revisit by looking at a list of visited sites, most frequently visited or saved websites.

First steps in formulating a conceptual model

- What will the users be doing when carrying out their tasks?
- How will the system support these?
- What kind of interface metaphor, if any, will be appropriate?
- What kinds of interaction modes and styles to use?
 - always keep in mind when making design decisions how the user will understand the underlying conceptual model

Conceptual models

- Many kinds and ways of classifying them
- We describe them in terms of core activities and objects
- Also in terms of interface metaphors